
**Unit 1, Option D,
Topic D6: Ideology,
Conflict and
Retreat: the USA in
Asia, 1950-73**

The focus of this topic is on the United States' reaction to ideological and political developments in Asia which the US considered threatening to its interests and, in particular, the resulting military involvement in Korea and south-east Asia. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example, about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four content bullet points offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of power and the influence of ideology on decision making and the exercise of power. The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the increasing intervention in south-east Asia by the US would straddle bullet points 2 and 3.

The first bullet point relates to the situation in Korea which led to US military commitment on a large scale following the attack on the Republic of Korea by the forces of Kim Il Sung in June of 1950. Students should have an understanding of how this North Korean attack came about and how and why the USA reacted in the way it did. They should understand how and why the war evolved, in particular why and with what consequences China intervened, why a stalemate developed and why an armistice took so long to arrange. They should understand the reasons for Truman's sacking of MacArthur and consider the degree of success achieved by the USA's intervention.

The second bullet point relates to the situation in south east Asia between 1950 and 1954. Students should understand the reasons for the US financial help to the French and the US role in the Geneva Peace Conference in July of 1954. The reference to the British in Malaysia is a reminder of the wider context of US policy and questions will not be set specifically on either British or French policies in the region, but students should understand the reasons for the setting up of SEATO in September 1954 and who was involved.

The third bullet point relates to the escalating US participation in the conflict in Vietnam under three successive presidents. Students should understand the reasons for limited intervention under Eisenhower and the nature of the relationship with the regime of Diem. They should understand why Kennedy despatched special forces and dramatically increased the number of 'advisers'. Finally, they should understand the reasons for the massive escalation under Johnson and its consequences. They should have an understanding of the human and financial cost and the significance of the Tet Offensive of 1968 and the debate within the USA on the conduct of the war.

The fourth bullet point relates to the Nixon presidency and the attempt to achieve 'peace with honour'. Students should understand the policy of 'Vietnamisation' the attempts to use air power to put pressure on North Vietnam and the significance of the changing Cold War context. They should address the significance of the popular protest movement in the USA and the growing doubts within the political elite.